note revealed that CM Majhi and a slew of top BJP leaders would visit the district the following day. The visit had not been mentioned in Majhi's earlier press briefings. Patnaik also met farmers in the Puri, Kendrapara and Jagatsinghpur districts, where adoring crowds greeted him. It was the same in September and October last year, when Patnaik visited Ganesh Puja and Durga Puja pandals in the state capital. Frenzied crowds gathered, with many cheering, taking selfies and even shedding tears.

That warmth underscored his deep-rooted connection with the people of Odisha. Political analyst Kedar Mishra notes, "The reaction of the crowd is a testament to Patnaik's enduring appeal. In fact, now that he has returned to the forefront, his popularity seems even greater." He attributes Patnaik's earlier decline to "power fatigue" after 24 years in office, suggesting that his new Opposition role has reinvigorated him. Notably, despite the electoral loss, the BJD is still ahead in terms of vote share, with 40.22 per cent compared to the BJP's 40.07 per cent.

The BJP, however, dismisses reports of Patnaik's growing popularity as a manufactured narrative. "The BJD is using this to keep its crumbling party intact. Naveen Babu didn't visit the districts as CM," says BJP spokesperson Anil Biswal. Nevertheless, admiration for Patnaik remains widespread, even within Biswal's own party. Union minister Giriraj Singh recently suggested that both Patnaik and Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar deserve the Bharat Ratna for their contributions. However, Patnaik characteristically understated it: "I have no idea why he said that."

The BJD's revival strategy has been multifaceted. At the party's headquarters, Sankha Bhawan, Patnaik has made regular appearances, meeting with workers and leaders. This accessibility extends to Naveen Niwas as well, where the once heavily restricted gates are open for party workers and supporters. His recognition of Rajya Sabha MP Sulata Deo's parliamentary performance during a gathering was particularly notable. For Deo, who had worked in the party for nearly a decade, it was a rare and touching moment. And she isn't alone. Many party leaders have experienced a renewed camaraderie with their leader since Patnaik began regularly meeting them in August. Prasanna Acharya, a long-time confidant, former parliamentarian and now deputy leader of the Opposition, candidly admits, "He was largely unavailable in recent years, for various reasons. But now, he's as accessible as he was in his early days."

A key element of Patnaik's strategy following the poll defeat was the introduction of a 'shadow cabinet', assigning specific portfolios to his party's 51 MLAs. This move ensures that every legislator remains active and engaged. According to a former BJD minister, they collect details of departmental operations through the standing committees and prepare their attack accordingly; a task that has given everyone a sense of purpose.

The BJP, however, is not a mute spectator in all of this. With Odisha a key focus of its eastern expansion strategy, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has poured both resources and attention into the state. In the BJP's narrative, the BJD is portrayed as a party of the past, incapable of addressing contemporary challenges. Modi, on the other hand, wants to turn Odisha into a BJP bastion, much like what he did in Gujarat, and the stakes couldn't be higher.

Patnaik's challenges aren't just external. Within the BJD, dissatisfaction lingers. Former minister Amar Prasad Satpathy openly criticised Patnaik's leadership, blaming him for the party's poor performance. His age, and therefore his health and longevity, is a pressing concern for a party that has long revolved around him. Yet, for now, the mood within the BJD is optimistic. Patnaik's presence at key events, from the BJD's foundation day celebrations to membership drives and blood donation camps, has reinvigorated the party's base. His assertion during the foundation day event that the BJD would "serve Odisha for the next century" reflects his confidence and vision.

His critics, though, wonder if Patnaik can sustain this momentum and convert it into electoral success. The first litmus test for the BJD's revived strategies will be in 2027, when panchayat elections are due to take place. ■

THE LEADER'S SECOND ACT

- **Opened the gates of his home Naveen Niwas, and met workers and leaders regularly to rebuild camaraderie and trust at party headquarters**
- **Assigned portfolios to all 51 MLAs, ensuring active participation and accountability within the party**
- **Engaged directly with people during festivals and events, showcasing a renewed connection with his constituents**
- **Visited key districts like Ganjam, Puri, Kendrapara and Jagatsinghpur, drawing massive crowds and reconnecting with supporters**
- **Held the BJD's first major protest in 20 years, targetting the BJP government and reigniting his party's base with powerful rhetoric**